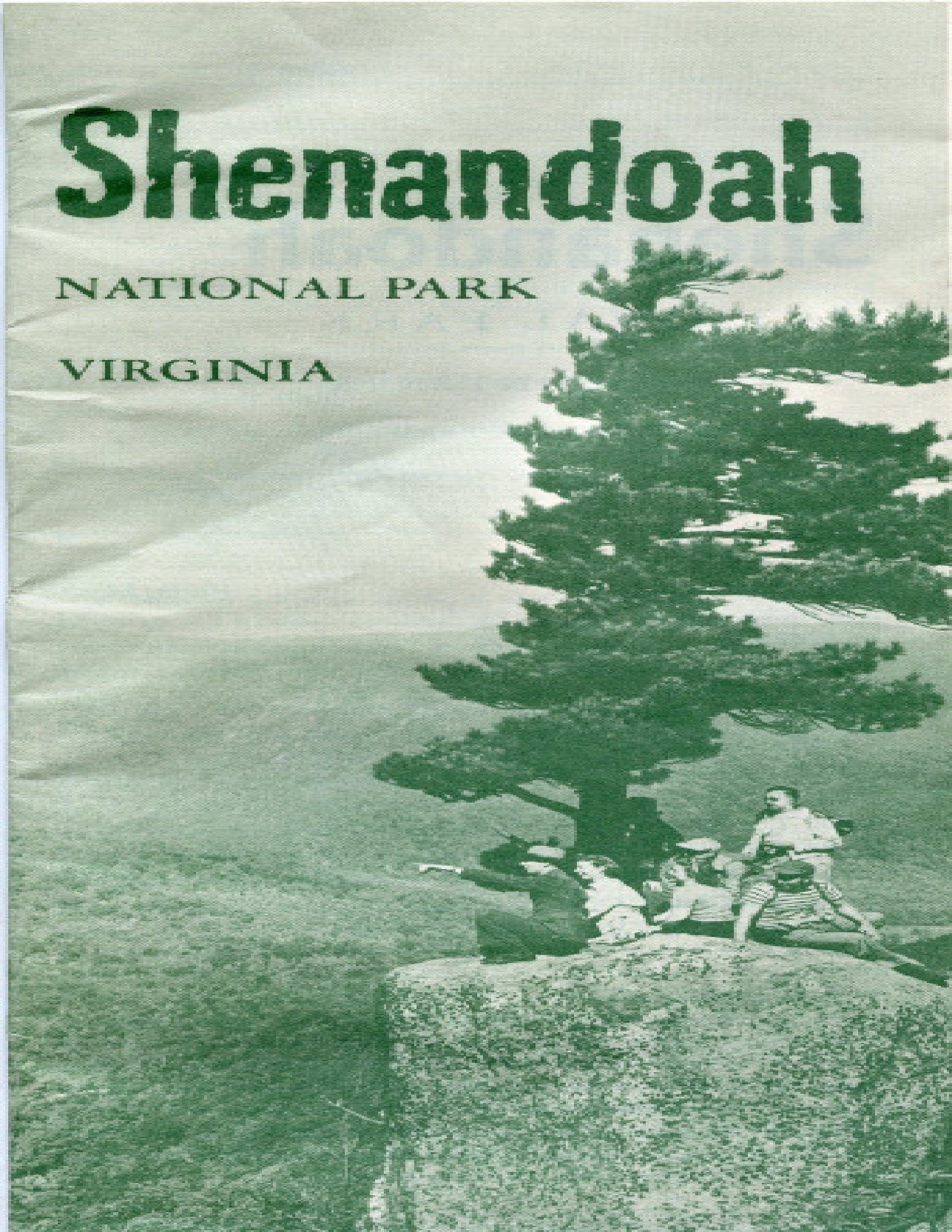


Shenandoah

NATIONAL PARK

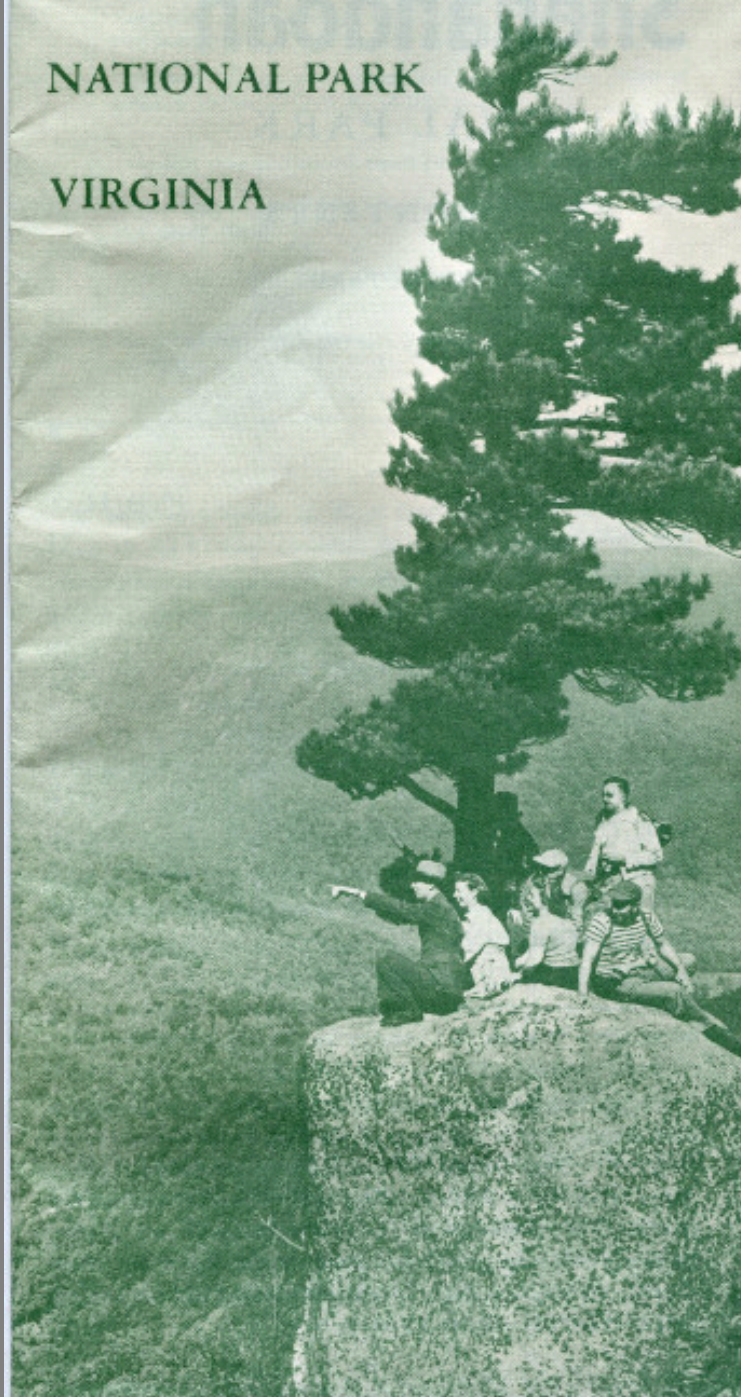
VIRGINIA



Shenandoah

NATIONAL PARK

VIRGINIA



The Project Gutenberg eBook of Shenandoah National Park, Virginia

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NATIONAL PARK, VIRGINIA ***

Cover: Hikers near summit of Old Rag.

Shenandoah

NATIONAL PARK

VIRGINIA

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Shenandoah is one of seven National Parks east of the Mississippi River. Set in the heart of the Blue Ridge Mountains of Virginia, its most celebrated features are the succession of panoramas from the crest of the ridge and the lush beauty of the slopes. This is your park—we of the National Park Service hope you will help protect and preserve it so that many future generations may enjoy it. The superintendent and his staff are here to help make your visit a happy one.

INTRODUCTION TO THE PARK

Like a great, hazy shadow against the sky, the Blue Ridge Mountains rise between the Piedmont and the Valley of Virginia. The 105-mile Skyline Drive winds along the Blue Ridge highland, crossing and recrossing the crest. It roughly bisects Shenandoah National Park, which encompasses over 300 square miles of scenic mountain country and claims 60 peaks that rise 3,000 to 4,000 feet. Seventy-five parking overlooks on the drive give you panoramic views of the Piedmont to the east and Shenandoah River Valley to the west. From Hogback Overlook, on a clear day, you can count 11 bends in the river and look down on fertile valleys where Indian villages once stood.

To know Shenandoah National Park, to discover its secrets, you must take time to stop, look, and listen. For adventure, you must explore. Leave your car at one of the overlooks or visitor-use areas, and hike or ride horseback along the trail. Between the drive and the park's boundaries are miles of ridges and valleys, hills and hollows, laced with sparkling streams and waterfalls. Trout lurk in shadowed pools, and wild gardens of rock, vines, shrubs, and wildflowers nestle only a short walk from the busy roadway.

At night, take time to look down on the twinkling lights of Luray, in Shenandoah Valley, and to see the stars through air so crystal-clear they seem almost within reach. On a rainy day, watch the fog roll in like a tidal wave; on a sunny day, see the cloud shadows sweep across hill and valley.

FUN IN THE PARK

Dickey Ridge Visitor Center.

This should be your starting point, if you enter the park from the north, for it is just inside mile 4.6 (see pp. [10](#)-13 for mileposts). Wherever you enter, be sure to stop here sometime before you leave the park. Ranger-naturalists are on hand to orient you and help you get all the information you need on hiking or camping, or whatever you plan to do. A short sequence of color slides will give you a general introduction to the park. The program describes the variety of park attractions—trails, wildlife, wildflowers, geology, and history.

Visitor Activities Program.

During the summer, ranger-naturalists conduct a number of field trips daily to points of interest and give nightly campfire programs at Skyland, Big Meadows, or Lewis Mountain. The entire family can enjoy these park-sponsored activities. In spring and autumn, park naturalists present evening talks at concession lodges. For the “do-it-yourself” visitor, self-guiding nature trails are open throughout the year.

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SOME TRAILS OF SHENANDOAH NATIONAL PARK

Name of Trail	Starts	Round Trip		Remarks
		Miles	Time	
Marys Rock	Mile 31.5	3.6	3 hrs.	Steady climb for 1.8 miles but easy return. Broad sweep of scenery in every direction.
Little Stony Man	Mile 39.1	1.5	1 hr.	Steep 385-foot climb for 0.6 mile of forest trail. Splendid view of Shenandoah Valley.
Stony Man	Mile 41.8	1.5	2 hrs.	Easy grade. Self-guiding nature trail through the woods; startlingly beautiful vista atop Stony Man profile.
Whiteoak Canyon	Mile 42.6 (Conducted walk from Mile 43)	5	½ day	Cool walk through the woods; long pull returning. First of series of six waterfalls at end of trail.

Limberlost	Mile 42.6	1.5 2 hrs.	Easy walk through hemlock forest (first part of Whiteoak trail).
Upper Hawksbill	Mile 46.6	2 1½ hrs.	To summit of Hawksbill Mountain, highest in park. Shady but steady climb.
Dark Hollow Falls	Mile 50.5	1.5 1 hr.	Shady trail; fairly steep climb returning. Falls drop sheerly 50 feet.
Big Meadows Swamp	Mile 51.2 (Big Meadows Amphitheater)	2 2 hrs.	No climbing; trail through swamp and woodland. Self-guiding.



Whiteoak Canyon Falls.

A complete schedule of these free interpretive activities is found in the *Visitor Activities Program*, available at all park and concession installations in Shenandoah National Park, or by writing to the Park Superintendent, Luray, Va. 5

Hiking.

The park is a hiker's paradise, with over 200 miles of foot trails, including a 94-mile link of the famous Appalachian Trail, which extends more than 2,000 miles from Maine to Georgia. The park maintains a series of open shelters along the trails, conveniently spaced a day's hike apart. Each hiker should bring his own bedroll for use on one of the six spring-covered bunks furnished in most of the shelters. These bunks are occupied on a first-come, first-served basis.

Detailed hikers' guides and maps of the trail system can be ordered by mail. (See [p. 22](#), PREPARING FOR YOUR VISIT.)

Horseback riding.

There are about 25 miles of scenic horse trails in the park. Horses (and ponies for children) can be rented at hourly rates at Skyland and Big Meadows.

Photography.

A filter is advisable when you are taking panoramic views, for haze is often present without your even noticing it. You will get better definition and more interesting shadows if you take your pictures in the morning or late afternoon, rather than in the flat light of midday.

With a long exposure you can get most dramatic photographs at sunset 6 when the trees and rocks stand out against the western sky in silhouette. Don't be afraid to go out and shoot black-and-white film in the fog or during a storm; cloud effects often are more striking than ever. If you want good pictures of wildlife, a telephoto lens will help.

Fishing.

The fun of fishing awaits the eager angler along the park streams. There, to try your skill, are native brook trout. At the park entrance stations you can

get rules and regulations governing angling and also directions to fishing waters. You will need a Virginia fishing license. A 3-day limit, nonresident trout fishing license is available at all concession units in the park for \$3.

Picnicking.

Campers and picnickers come from all over to take advantage of Shenandoah's superb facilities for 9 months of the year. Fireplaces make it easy to prepare steaks or fish or even pancakes. Your frying pan rests on a grill as steady as your own stove. Choose one of the picnic areas along the drive for your evening meal, and then walk out and watch the sunset. (Picnic grounds are noted on the map, pp. [10](#)-13.)

AT HOME IN THE PARK

Where To Stay.

All of the lodging and restaurant facilities, the gift shops, and service stations in Shenandoah National Park are operated by the Virginia Sky-Line Co., Inc. While types of accommodations in the park are limited, there is a wide choice of cabins, tourist homes, motels, and hotels in nearby communities, which are available the year round.

Hotel-type accommodations may be obtained in the park at Big Meadows. Cabins, with rooms and private connecting baths, may be rented at Skyland, Big Meadows, and Lewis Mountain. These accommodations are closed during winter. There are no cabins equipped for housekeeping.

As rates are subject to change from season to season, no prices for facilities are given in this booklet. Reservations and rates may be secured from the Virginia Sky-Line Co., Inc., Luray, Va. Whenever possible, lodging reservations should be made in advance, particularly from early July through October. You are urged to plan your trip to the park during the middle of the week to avoid congested periods over weekends.

Camping.

Campers and picnickers should bring camp stoves or fuel for fireplaces since wood is not always available. Food supplies, ice, charcoal burners, and fuel may be obtained at Big Meadows Wayside. Electricity is not available. Use of campgrounds is free but is limited to 14 days in any one year. Reservations for campsites cannot be made; the policy is first come, first served.

Shelters.

There are 20 open shelters, each sleeping 6 persons (see map, pp. [10](#)-13); they cannot be reserved, and hikers must bring their own bedding. However, locked, equipped cabins are available by reservation from the Potomac Appalachian Trail Club, 1916 Sunderland Place NW., Washington 6, D. C. A small nightly charge is made for the locked cabins.

Restaurants

are operated by the Virginia Sky-Line Company at Panorama, Skyland, Big Meadows, and Big Meadows Wayside, Lewis Mountain, and Swift Run Gap. Light lunches are available at Elkwallow; groceries, at Big Meadows Wayside.

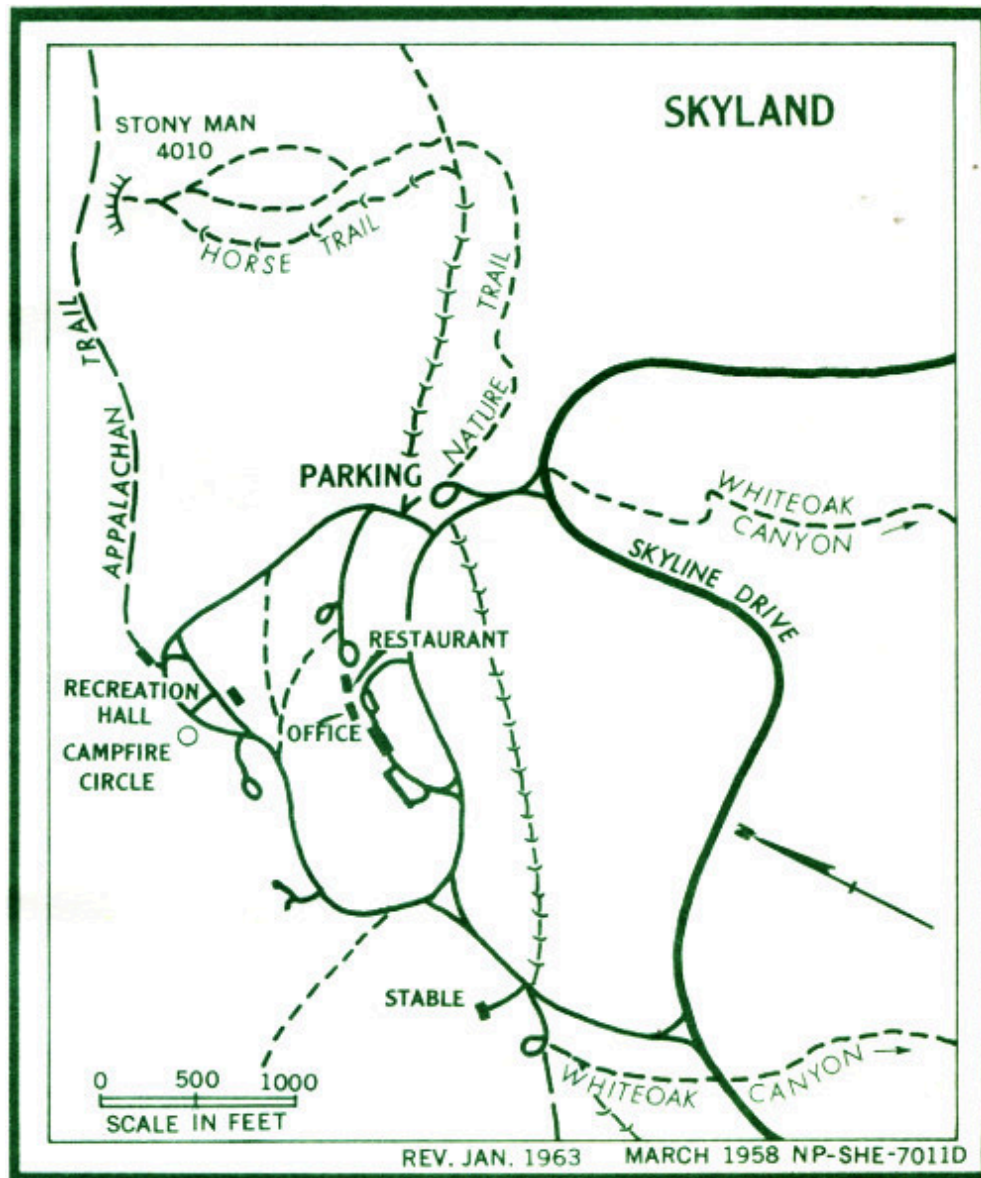
Mail

is delivered daily to the lodges; campers should direct their mail to be sent in care of General Delivery, Luray, Va.

Long-distance telephone service

is available 24 hours a day at the developed areas.

SKYLAND



SKYLAND
REV. JAN. 1963 MARCH 1958 NP-SHE-7011D

STONY MAN 4010
HORSE TRAIL
APPALACHIAN TRAIL
NATURE TRAIL

PARKING
WHITEOAK CANYON
SKYLINE DRIVE
RESTAURANT
RECREATION HALL
OFFICE
CAMPFIRE CIRCLE
STABLE

Skyland, at 3,680 feet elevation, is the highest point on Skyline Drive. Here in the largest of the park's developed areas are accommodations for 350 persons. The lodge is the center of the community, with groups of multiple-unit cottages scattered within walking distance along the ridge and under the trees. Besides dining room, coffeeshop, and gift shop, there are lounges 8 for use on chilly nights and a terrace for lazy sunning.

Skyland is the starting point for many of the guided walks and horseback trips; stables are just downhill from the lodge. The campfire circle is the scene of naturalist talks on fine evenings; in rainy weather you will find them in the recreation hall, "under the hill."

Don't leave this area until you hike the 1½-mile round trip to Stony Man Mountain. You saw the rock profile in view for many miles if you approached Skyland from the north. From this cliff of weathered, greenstone rock, the view is sheerly downward to the valley, and sweepingly across to the Massanutten Mountain, a hazy blue in the distance. The half-day hikes to Whiteoak Canyon, and to the summit of Marys Rock (trail starts at Panorama), as well as shorter walks to Millers Head, Little Stony Man Cliffs, and Hawksbill Mountain, are most easily reached from Skyland.

BIG MEADOWS

Second largest of the developed areas, Big Meadows has a hospitable lodge with spacious veranda, surrounded by individual cottages. These, together with a few lodge rooms, accommodate 250 persons. Tent, trailer, and picnic grounds are a part of the development. The lodge dining room is open to all visitors. At Big Meadow Wayside, you will find a coffeeshop, small grocery store, gift shop, and service station. Horseback trips from Big Meadows begin near the ranger station.

The great charm of Big Meadows lies in its open fields, in contrast to the forests on every hand. The fragrant meadows once were heavily grazed, keeping down the trees that only now, after 30 years, are starting to come back.

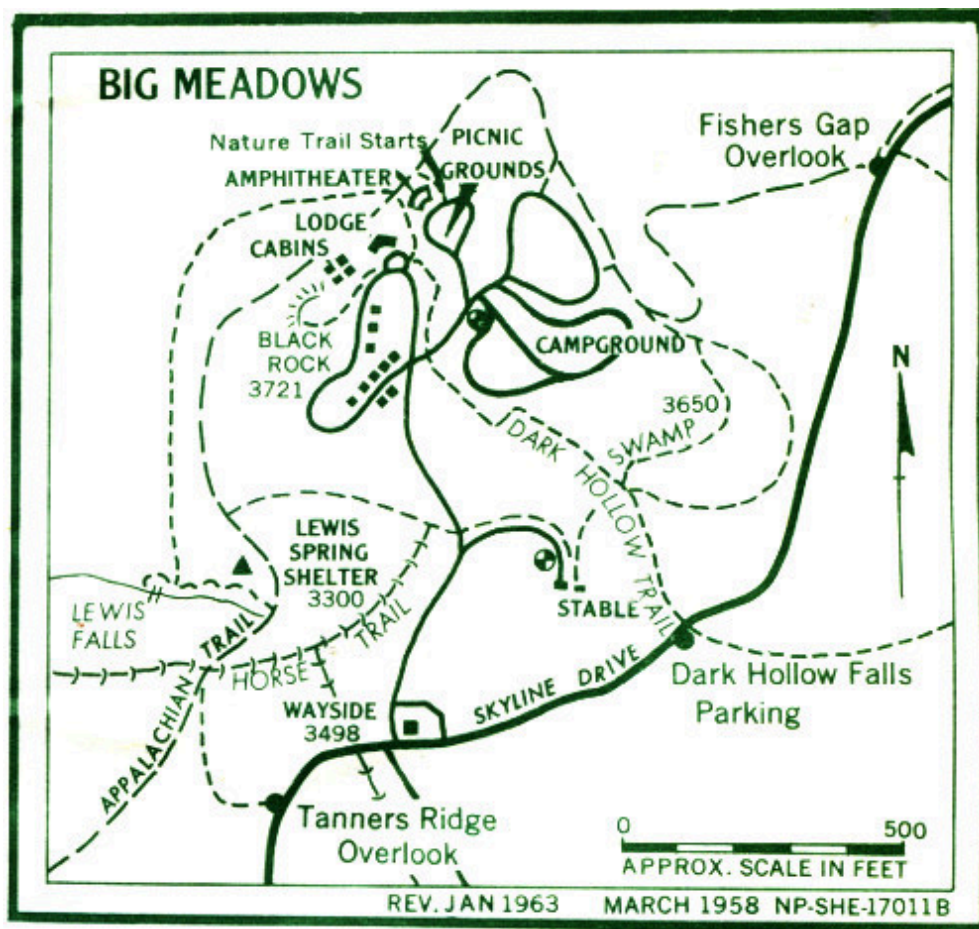
Of considerable interest is a swamp in one part of the fields, destination of the self-guiding trail fittingly called the Swamp Trail. Usually the pathway is quite dry, but in the damp areas nearby is an unusual variety of vegetation—gray birch, cardinal flower, and American burnet, all rare in the park. Remnants of the ghost forest of gaunt chestnut trees still stand. From the edge of the meadows there are fine views of the valley. An equally relaxing walk of another kind—along a forest trail—is to Dark Hollow Falls, a round trip of 3½ miles from the lodge.

Campfire talks are held in the amphitheater several times a week in summer, and in the lodge in spring and autumn.

LEWIS MOUNTAIN

At mile 57.6, Lewis Mountain is the southernmost and the smallest accommodations area in the park—room for only 24 people. But besides the cabins, there is a coffeeshop and camp and picnic grounds. Park naturalists present campfire programs during the summer.

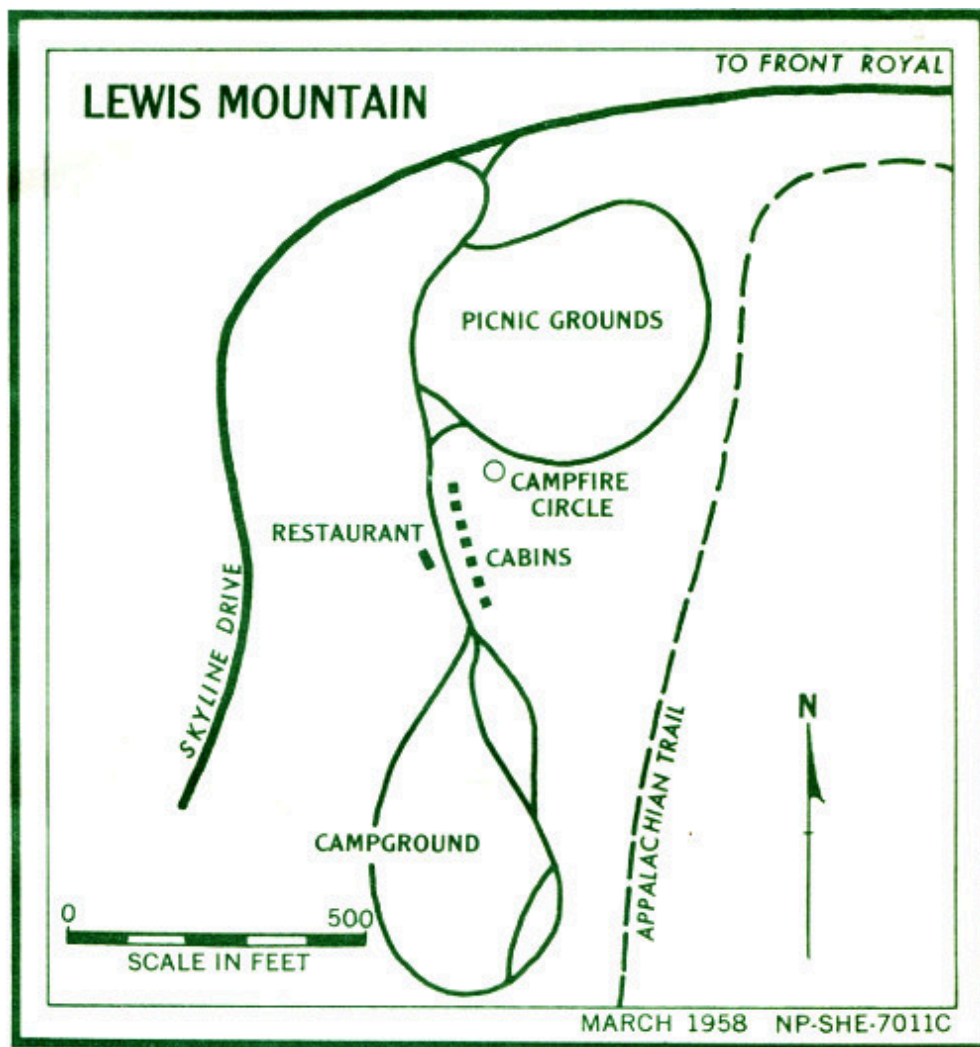
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BIG MEADOWS
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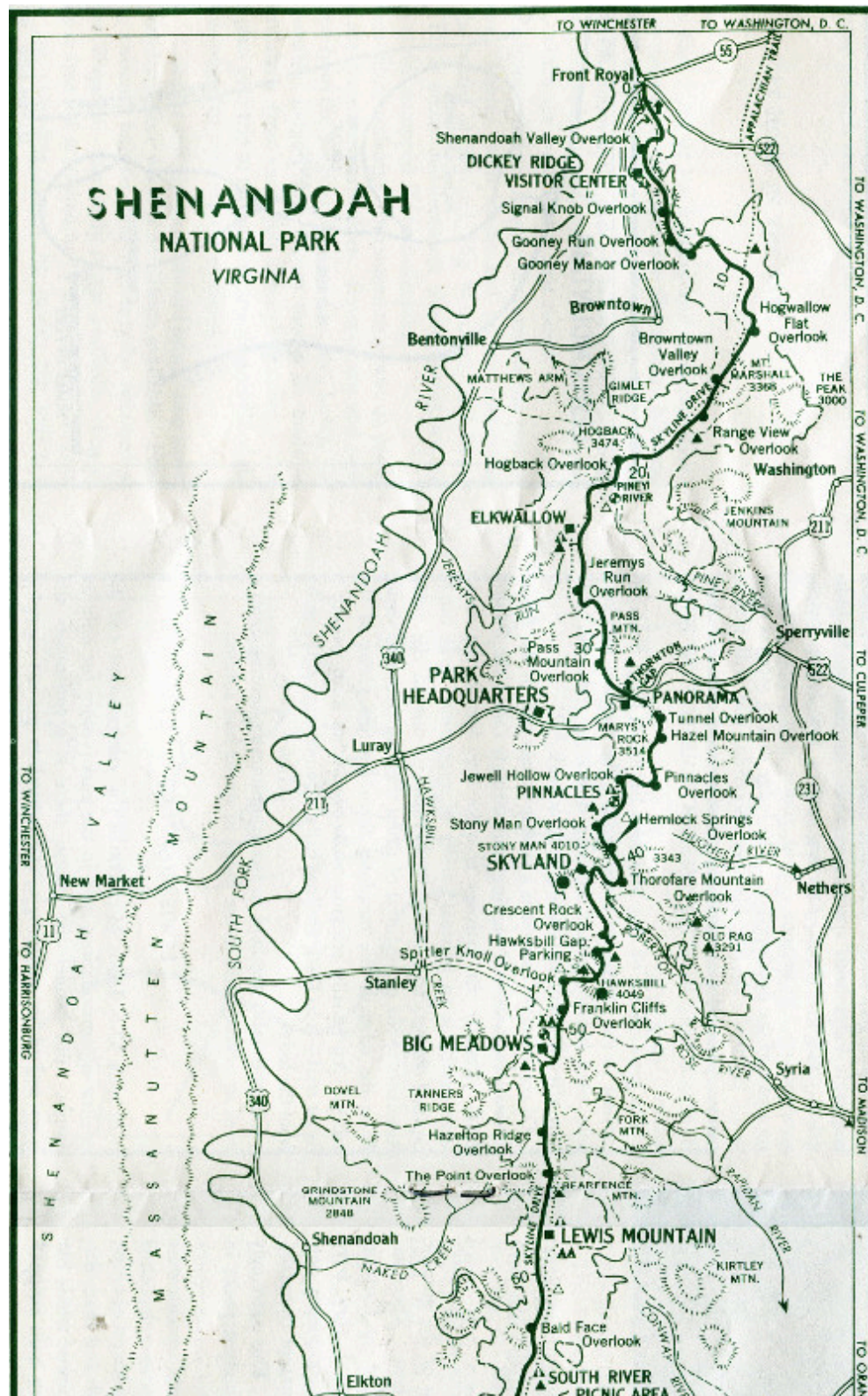
NATURE TRAIL STARTS
PICNIC GROUNDS
FISHERS GAP OVERLOOK
AMPHITHEATER

LODGE
CABINS
CAMPGROUND
BLACK ROCK 3721
3650
SWAMP
DARK HOLLOW TRAIL
LEWIS SPRING SHELTER 3300
STABLE
LEWIS FALLS
APPALACHIAN TRAIL
HORSE TRAIL
SKYLINE DRIVE
DARK HOLLOW FALLS
PARKING
WAYSIDE 3498
TANNERS RIDGE OVERLOOK



LEWIS MOUNTAIN
MARCH 1958 NP-SHE-7011C

TO FRONT ROYAL
PICNIC GROUNDS
RESTAURANT
CAMPFIRE CIRCLE
CABINS
SKYLINE DRIVE
APPALACHIAN TRAIL



SHENANDOAH NATIONAL PARK
VIRGINIA

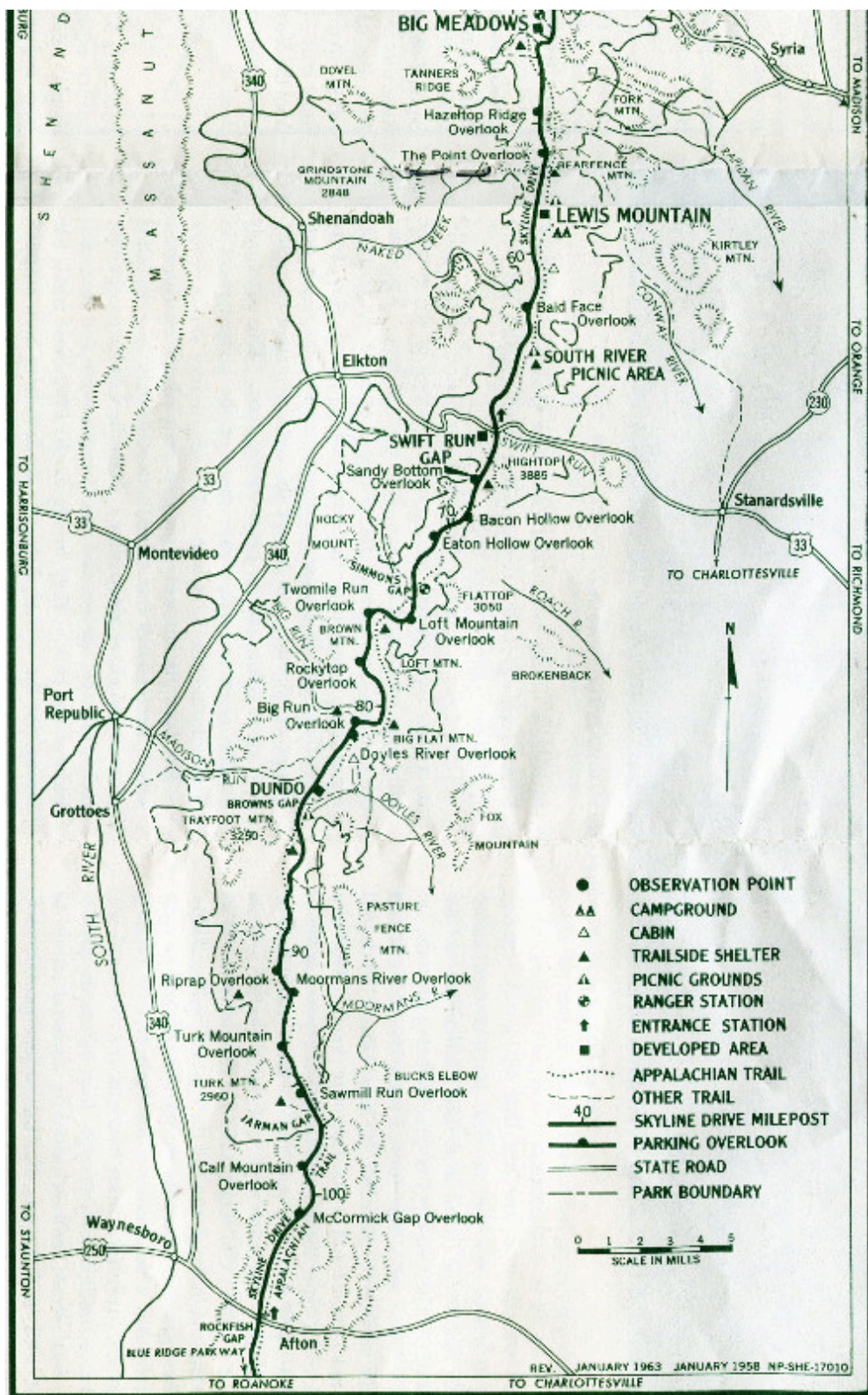
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THE SKYLINE DRIVE

The drive is 105 miles long from Front Royal to Rockfish Gap. Mileposts numbered from north to south are keyed to the map on the left, and to the table below. Symbols indicate developed areas (accommodations, restaurants, service stations); entrance and ranger stations; camp and picnic grounds; trail cabins and shelters; roads and trails. Most picnic grounds have fireplaces; all have tables and water.

NOTE: Dates given for accommodations areas vary with weather conditions from season to season.

Mile	Point of Interest	Elevation, Feet
0.0	Junction with US. 340	595
0.6	North Entrance Station	705
2.8	Shenandoah Valley Overlook. First important view of the valley 900 ft. below. Directly opposite is Signal Knob. Civil War communications post, on Massanutten Mountain	1,390
4.6	Dickey Ridge Visitor Center. Exhibits and programs to explain park. Information, bookstore, maps. Restrooms. Picnic grounds nearby. Telephone. Open daily Apr. through Oct.	
17.1	Range View Overlook. Piedmont Plateau; Blue Ridge peaks	2,810
20.1	Hogback Overlook. Eleven bends in Shenandoah River visible on clear day	3,385
24.1	Elkwallo. Picnic grounds. Lunch, souvenirs, gasoline. May through Oct.	2,445
31.5	Panorama (Thornton Gap Entrance Station). Intersection with U.S. 211. Dining room, lunch counter, gift shop, service station. Open all year. Trail to Marys Rock. Park headquarters 4 miles west on U.S. 211; 8 miles to Luray	2,300
32.4	Marys Rock Tunnel cut through 700 feet of rock (13-foot clearance)	2,545
36.7	Pinnacles. Picnic grounds	3,550
37.4	Pinnacles Ranger Station	3,215



**SHENANDOAH NATIONAL PARK
VIRGINIA**

[High-resolution Image](#)

13

Mile	Point of Interest	Elevation, Feet
37.4	Pinnacles Ranger Station	3,215
39.2	Little Stony Man Parking Area. 1½-mile-round-trip trail to sweeping view of Shenandoah Valley	3,210
41.8	Entrance to Skyland. Lodge rooms, cottages, dining room, coffeeshop, gift shop, riding horses. Accommodations for 350. May through Oct. Stony Man Nature Trail Parking Area	3,680
42.6	Whiteoak Canyon Parking Area. 5-mile-round-trip trail to falls	3,510
44.5	Crescent Rock Overlook. Best view of Hawksbill Mountain, highest in park	3,550
46.6	Upper Hawksbill Gap Parking Area. 2-mile-round-trip trail to summit of Hawksbill	3,400
50.5	Dark Hollow Falls Parking Area. 1½-mile-round-trip trail to falls	3,070
51.3	Big Meadows Wayside. Coffeeshop, gift shop, service station, campers' store. Apr. through Oct. Entrance to Big Meadows. Lodge, dining room, hotel rooms, and cottages. Gift shop, riding horses. Accommodations for 250. Apr. through Oct. Camp and trailer sites, picnic grounds. Showers and automatic laundry. Big Meadows Nature Trail. Ranger station.	3,500
57.6	Lewis Mountain. Coffeeshop, cabin accommodations for 24, Apr. through Oct. Camp and trailer sites, picnic grounds	3,390
62.9	South River. Picnic grounds; 2½-mile-round-trip trail to falls	2,940
65.7	Swift Run Gap. Intersection with U.S. 33. Dining room, gift shop, service station. Apr. to mid-Nov.	2,365
73.2	Simmons Gap Ranger Station	2,245
78.2	Rockytop Overlook. Big Run watershed, wild canyon scenery, trails	2,860
90.1	Calvary Rocks Parking Area. 2-mile-round-trip trail	2,730
104.6	South Entrance Station	2,070
105.4	Rockfish Gap; intersection with US. 250; 5 miles to Humpback Rocks Visitor Center—Blue Ridge Parkway	1,910

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The mountains of the Blue Ridge are rounded by ages of erosion.

GEOLOGY

Geologists tell us how the rounded, forest-covered mountains of the Blue Ridge record more than a billion years of the earth's history. The two types of granitic basement rocks are the oldest. These rocks were formed many thousands of feet beneath the surface of the earth, as large masses of magma (molten rock) cooled and crystallized very slowly. One type of granitic rock (hypersthene granodiorite) is exposed at Marys Rock Tunnel, and along the crest and on the western flank of the Blue Ridge. The other type is a much coarser grained granite. It is named Old Rag granite for exposures found on that mountain and in the area east of the crest of the Blue Ridge. Both of these granitic rocks were changed by heat and pressure (metamorphism), which accounts for their layered or laminated (gneissic) textures at many locations.

Hundreds of millions of years ago, long before the present landscape was formed, erosion carved an ancestral terrain of mountains, hills, and canyons into the ancient granitic rock. There were no trees, wildflowers, or animals to relieve the barrenness of the wind- and rain-swept landscape. A half-15 billion years ago, only a few primitive plants (algae) may have spotted the jagged granite hills.

Then, from a series of long cracks or fissures in the earth, layer after layer of lava poured out until most of the granitic hills were submerged in a vast, level plain of lava. These basaltic outpourings formed the principal rocks of the Catoctin formation. Long after the lavas had hardened, they were radically altered by intense metamorphism into completely new groups of minerals, which give the rock its present characteristic green color, and its name—greenstone. This extremely durable greenstone schist caps many of the highest peaks in Shenandoah.

The lava plateau sank slowly beneath advancing Paleozoic seas. Some 30,000 feet of sea-floor sediments were deposited in a vast trough, or geosyncline. Only the very lowest or oldest rocks from this age are now found in the north and south districts of the park. They belong to the

Chilhowee series, but throughout the central district even these have been stripped by erosion from the crest of the Blue Ridge.

Near the end of the Paleozoic era (some 180 million years ago), the 16 sediments of the Appalachian geosyncline were subjected to intense compression by tremendous unknown forces acting from the southeast. These intense pressures slowly wrinkled, folded, shoved, and fractured the ancient granites, lavas, and sea-floor sediments into a great original Appalachian mountain system, which stood several times higher than the present mountains. Most of the younger rocks were shoved into parallel mountain ridges to the west of the Blue Ridge and now form the Allegheny Mountains. Continuous erosion has stripped thousands of feet of material from the former alplike mountains. Vast quantities of this material have been transported to the sea. Some of it was deposited in local basins to the east during the Triassic period. The Triassic redbeds are now being uncovered by erosion along Lee Highway (U.S. 211) and in the road cuts west of Bull Run or Manassas Battlefield. Even today the geologic forces continue, almost unnoticed, to change and shape the land.

PLANTS

Ninety-five percent of the Blue Ridge is wooded, and much of this forest is made up of scarlet, red, and chestnut oaks. On the ridges and dry slopes there may also be hickory, black locust, black birch, and scattered maple, black gum, ash, and pine. In moister coves there is a greater variety of species including white oak, maple, birch, yellow-poplar, sycamore, and basswood. In cooler coves and on north slopes, hemlocks are dominant. At higher elevations, red spruce and balsam fir stand as relics of the northern forest type that covered the Blue Ridge during the more arctic conditions of the Pleistocene Age.

The limberlost at the head of Whiteoak Canyon contains hemlocks that are over 400 years old and 3 feet in diameter. The dead trunks of some giant American chestnuts are still standing, but these trees are no longer a part of the Blue Ridge forest—they were killed out by the chestnut blight. The forests of 300 years ago were cut for wood products and to clear land, and their regrowth was prevented by fire and grazing.

Today's forest contains mostly small trees. The older oaks along the exposed ridge lines have been twisted and broken by ice and wind. In many places open fields are becoming overgrown with scrub pine, black locust, sassafras, and other early invaders. These lead the way for the return of the climax oak forest that will again someday clothe the mountains.

The changing seasons make the variety of Shenandoah's woody plants conspicuous. The flowers of redbud, dogwood, wild cherry, black locust, azalea, and mountain laurel make spring a veritable fairyland. The autumn color parade begins with black gum and red maple, varied and added to by hickories, dogwood, ash, and sassafras, until the climax of oaks makes the slopes blaze with red and orange, then subside to russet and brown. The gray of winter branches is relieved only by the dark green of pine, spruce, fir, and hemlock.

From March to November, you will find flowers blooming in the Blue Ridge. So many kinds: 80 different flowering plants can be identified

in a day's walk.

In the spring, hepatica and masses of violets, bluets, and marsh marigolds brave the uncertain weather of March and April, followed by the bloodroot, trillium, and jack-in-the-pulpit. Summer brings great clumps of goldenrod and Queen Anne's lace, asters, daisies, and black-eyed-susans along the roadside. In the fields look for columbine, the showy turks-cap lily, and the purple thistle.

Autumn's brilliant leaves compete with the flower displays, but many varieties hold their own—goldenrod, asters, chicory, yarrow, fireweed, and ironweed. To all these are added the bright fruits of the dogwood, white baneberry, sumac, and mountain ash. It is no wonder that October draws more visitors to the park than any other month except July.

WILDLIFE

Birds.

This park is an exciting place for birdwatchers who could, if they had time and patience, spot more than 100 different species at the height of the spring migration (April and May). Other migrants bring the year's total to 200.

You will notice first of all the soaring birds—buzzards, vultures, and ravens—because they are constantly “floating” over mountaintops and valleys. Take a few minutes to watch the raven do his stunts. He's the acrobat of the park's bird population. Like a highly maneuverable aircraft, he dives and stalls, somersaults and soars for hours on end, apparently with no aim but to have a good time.

On the roadside, watch for the indigo bunting and junco, the ruffed grouse, and, in the southern part of the park, the wild turkey. Along the trail you will hear the towhee call his name; the hammering of the woodpecker; the call of the whip-poor-will and the mourning dove; the screech of the jay.

The woods are filled with songbirds; if you listen closely, you may hear oven-birds, red-eyed vireoes, nuthatches, chickadees, catbirds, wrens, brown-thrashers, and black-throated blue warblers.

Bring your bird guide along. You will find your hikes and walks greatly enriched by being able to identify the birds you see and hear, and you may introduce the whole family to a new interest that will reward you wherever you travel.

Mammals.

Because the Blue Ridge was dominated by man for over 200 years, wild animals both large and small became scarce. Now, under park protection, deer and bears, bobcats and foxes are increasing in number. Of these, most likely you will see the white-tailed deer in the early morning or evening in

open meadows. Watch for them at Skyland, near the Whiteoak parking area, at Big Meadows, and at the edge of the forests, particularly in the northern part of the park.

The woodchuck feeds all day long on the shoulders of the drive, but because he is the same color as the rocks, you may miss him. The friendly, noisy chipmunk you will find in camp and picnic grounds. Gray squirrels are numerous in the woods and cottontails in meadows and clearings. Flying squirrels are active only at night.

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Also, after dark be on the lookout for the pert, masked face of the raccoon. He, as well as the familiar black-and-white coat of the skunk, may turn up in the glare of your headlights.

Fishes.

An interesting assortment of native fishes lives in quiet pools and turbulent riffles of park streams. In cooler headwaters, brook trout find a favourite home. Suckers, shiners, dace, bass, and sunfish join the trout in warmer waters farther downstream. More than 20 kinds of fishes inhabit the park waters. The American eel makes its long migration from the Shenandoah streams to the Atlantic Ocean to spawn and then return upstream.

THE SEASONS

Shenandoah National Park is open the year round. However, you may occasionally find Skyline Drive closed for short periods because of ice, snow, or heavy fog. Big Meadows Campground is open the year around, and lodge and cottage accommodations are available from April through October; exact dates depend on the weather. Entrance fees are suspended during the winter.

Spring.

When the buds turn red on the maple trees, you know that spring is on the way to the Blue Ridge. Soon, the pale-green veil of new leaves begins to creep slowly—about a hundred feet a day—up the slopes from the valley floor until the mountainsides are painted with the color of spring. In the woods, the violets and marsh marigolds are blooming together in clumps beside the springs, and tiny blossoms appear everywhere in sunny patches on the forest floor. The air is crisp and fresh. Except for a few mild days, it is cold in the park until June. Along the drive, the dogwood and redbud bloom early, followed by azalea and black locust, and in early June by the delicate pink and white of laurel.

Summer.

These are the hazy, lazy days that often bring afternoon thunderstorms and spectacular waves of fog that sweep across the mountaintops and hide the valleys. Temperatures are a comfortable 15° lower than those in the valley—mid-80's in the daytime, mid-40's at night. At midday, the air is heavy with the damp, earthy smell of the woods, and the sweet scent of wildflowers in the fields. It is a good time of year to go for a leisurely walk in the woods, where shade is everywhere, or to pluck blackberries and blueberries in the Big Meadows. And if a shower catches up with you, you'll be dry again before you get back. We suggest that you take a short walk out to Stony Man or Crescent Rock and gaze at the incredible patchwork of farm and

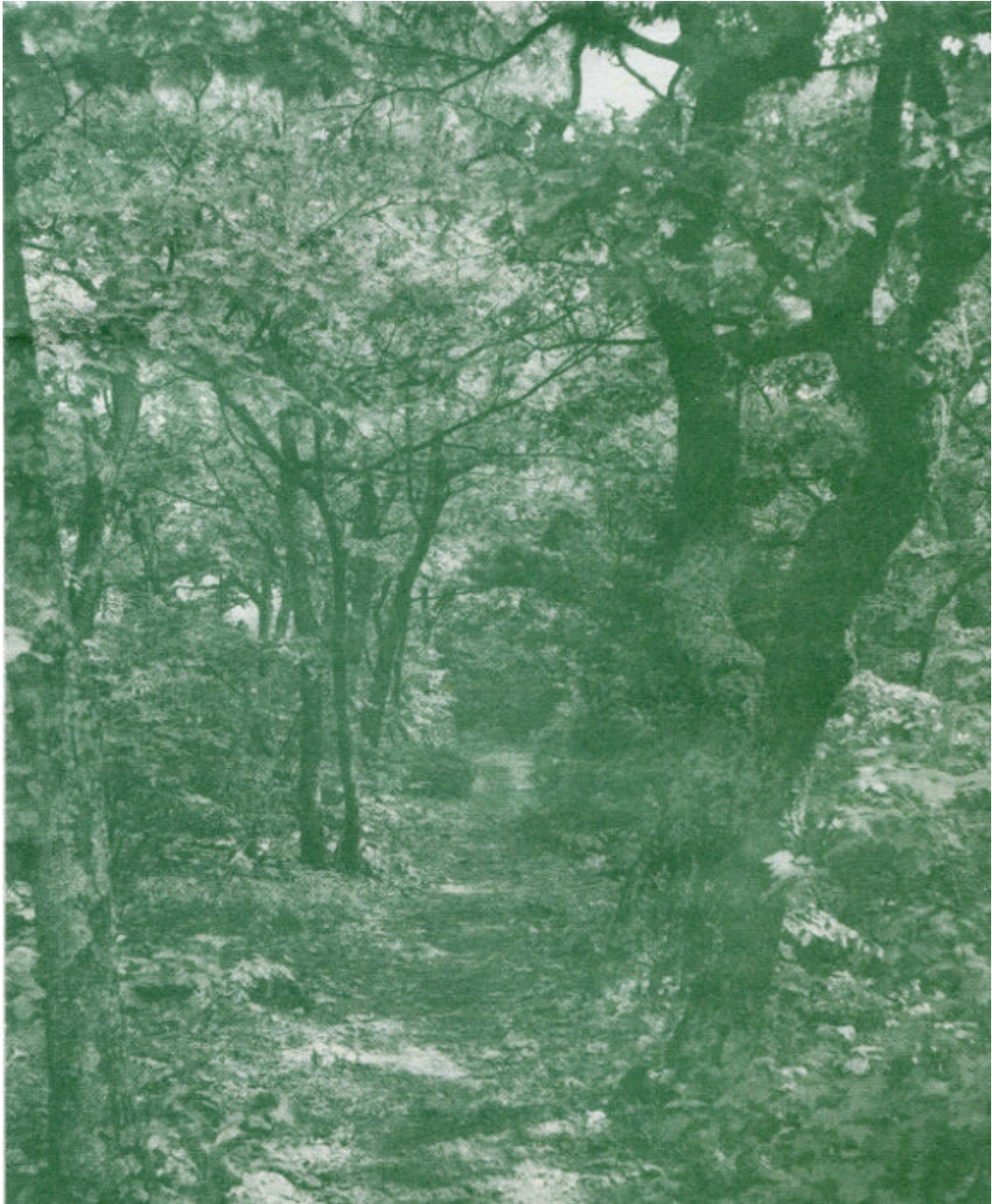
field in the valley below. Field glasses will add to your enjoyment of this view.

Autumn.

This time of year brings the “down-flowing” of autumn color from mountaintops to the coves and hollows. By mid-September the foliage has begun to change, starting with the Virginia creeper. Exquisite patches of color—the blood-red of the gum, the red and yellow of the maple—appear in large areas of green, and soon whole mountainsides have “caught fire.” There is a series of “color-peaks” as varied as the different latitudes and altitudes within the park, but the most lavish displays usually occur between October 10 and 20. This is hiking weather, and campfire-picnic weather.

Winter.

Do not discount the beauty of the Blue Ridge in winter when the trees shed their leaves and open up new vistas. Now, you can see long distances in every direction. The cold crisp days are brilliant, and the evergreens stand out like bright-green exclamations against the snowy white of the hillsides. After a storm, with the roads freshly cleared, you can come up and inspect Stony Man, who will be wearing a frosty beard. Gleaming icicles cascade over a cliff like a frozen Niagara. On crisp winter mornings observe the ghostly fog “fingers” that protrude from branches like ruffled white plumes.



A second-growth oak forest covers Stony Man Mountain.

HUMAN HISTORY

There is no record—except for isolated artifacts—of Indian inhabitants in Shenandoah National Park. The Shawnee and the Moneton, Saponi, and Manahoac were reported in the valleys during the 17th century, but they wandered into the mountains only occasionally to hunt.

It is not surprising, then, that John Lederer found only deer, bears, and wolves when he arrived in the present area of Big Meadows with his Indian guides. Virginia's Governor, Sir William Berkeley, had sent him, in 1669, to explore the unknown mountains. Lederer is the first known white man to venture into the uncharted Blue Ridge.

In 1716, Gov. Alexander Spotswood, also seeking westward expansion for Virginia, led 50 men on horseback through Swift Run Gap and down the western slope to see the Shenandoah Valley, where they camped by the river they called "Euphrates." After their return home Spotswood proclaimed them "Knights of the Golden Horseshoe," and presented each a tiny gold horseshoe.

Shortly afterward, English, German, and Scotch-Irish pioneers began to settle in the valleys. They gradually moved up into the coves and hollows of the Blue Ridge. By 1760, roads were being built, and grist mills, sawmills, cider presses, and tanneries were common sights. The first toll turnpike, in 1785, crossed the mountains at Thornton Gap (Panorama). It was named for Francis Thornton, who settled there in 1733. Other important roads crossed at Swift Run and Browns Gap, in the southern section of the park.

In the early years, the settlers of the Blue Ridge coves and hollows wrested a comfortable living from their farms and domestic industries. They sold lumber products and tanbark to the lowland settlers for cash and thus could buy things they could not produce.

For some 20 years before the Civil War, there was iron and copper mining in the Blue Ridge. The mountain people were not much affected by this short-lived industry and by the time the war came, the ores had been worked out.

You can see remnants of the old copper mines on the Stony Man Nature Trail.

During the Civil War, both the Piedmont and the Shenandoah Valley became battlegrounds; Browns Gap was used by Jackson as an important thoroughfare in the Campaign of 1862, and Signal Knob became a major communications point. You can see Signal Knob from the Shenandoah Valley Overlook.

When the railroad came to the Shenandoah Valley, heavy machinery and larger, more efficient industry came with it. Many mills and tanyards that served small communities through the skill and energy of one man or family became quiet, then decayed into the landscape. Demand for the mountaineers' crafts decreased. They had little cash income left except from moonshining and chestnuts. By 1915, the fungus chestnut blight had destroyed most of the chestnut trees.

Isolated from the rapidly changing lowlands, and with their forest and soil resources depleted, the mountain people were reduced to subsistence farming. 21

As the years passed, the population of the mountains east of the Shenandoah dwindled. However, there were still over 2,000 people living on the lands which were acquired by the State of Virginia for Shenandoah National Park. Before the land was deeded to the Federal Government, these people, more than 400 families, moved to new homes. The self-sufficient families moved without assistance. The very old and the disabled were helped by the State Welfare Department. About 300 families were moved into homesteads by the U. S. Resettlement Administration. Here each family had the use of a house and small farm with the privilege of long-term purchase.

A PARK EMERGES

The first official act in forming the park was the appointment of the Southern Appalachian National Park Committee. The Secretary of the Interior appointed the committee to survey the Blue Ridge and other eastern regions as sites for future National Parks. After hearing the report, local groups were formed to promote the project.

The Shenandoah National Park Association, formed in 1925, became an instrument of this movement. In 9 months its members raised \$1,249,000. Twenty-four thousand Virginians pledged this amount to buy up the necessary property at \$6 an acre. The Virginia Assembly voted an additional million dollars to help buy up the 3,870 private tracts, and in 1926 Congress formally authorized establishment of the park.

Eight years went by before the land was totally acquired. In the interim the Skyline Drive, which early had been visualized as one of the major attractions of the park, was begun in 1931. In 1934 the first section was opened to the public.

At Big Meadows, on July 3, 1936, Shenandoah National Park was dedicated “to present and succeeding generations of Americans for the recreation and the re-creation” they were to find there.

PRESERVING THE PARK

You may wonder why dead trees and fallen logs are not removed, why streams are not dammed for swimming, and why certain plants and animals are not brought into the park and others removed.

The answer is in the fundamental policy of the National Park Service to maintain the National Parks in their natural state. The landscape scars—remnants of roads and fences, and grazed-over land—will disappear in time. The forests will come back to cover the farmlands, and in its own way the wildlife will balance and adjust to this forest ecology. These are the things you see taking place in your National Parks all over the country.

And so we ask you not to disturb the flowers or trees in any way, and not to collect rock specimens. You can help to protect the wildlife by driving carefully. Hunting is prohibited anywhere in the park.

PREPARING FOR YOUR VISIT

Books and Maps.

Knowing something about the park before your visit will help you enjoy it more. You can order books and maps from the Shenandoah Natural History Association (a nonprofit organization), c/o Shenandoah National Park, Luray, Va., or buy them at the visitor center or at park headquarters. The association will send you a list of titles and prices. The following publications are representative.

The book, *Skyland, Heart of Shenandoah National Park*, based on the autobiography of George Freeman Pollock, contains early photographs. *The Mammals of Shenandoah National Park* describes the wildlife in the park with stories and photographs. The illustrated book, *101 Wildflowers of Shenandoah National Park*, is an excellent flower guide. Topographic trail maps of north, central, and south sections of the park and a booklet describe *20 Circuit Hikes*.

Describing not only Shenandoah, but all of our parks, is Freeman Tilden's *The National Parks*.

What To Bring.

Summer sportswear for daytime; sweaters and topcoats for evening (tuck in a raincoat, too). Bring sturdy shoes for walking; non-skid soles are good for rocks and slippery trails. Binoculars, or field glasses, will double your appreciation of the park, especially of its birds and animals. Do not forget your camera; film is available at the lodges.

HOW TO REACH THE PARK

There are four main entrances to the park along the Skyline Drive. These are:

North Entrance (Front Royal, Va.): From U.S. 340 and Va. 55 and 522.

Thornton Gap (Mile 31.6): From U.S. 211.

Swift Run Gap (Mile 65.7): From U.S. 33.

South Entrance (Rockfish Gap): From U.S. 250, and from the Blue Ridge Parkway.

The Blue Ridge Parkway, when completed, will link Shenandoah National Park with Great Smoky Mountains National Park, a distance of 469 miles. A unit of the National Park System, the parkway is more than two-thirds complete. Short detours are well marked. Information on road conditions can be obtained at the entrance stations.

Bus service

is available at nearby towns all year. Virginia Trailways, Charlottesville, Va., operates tours to and through the park from late May through October. Call Trailways terminals for reservations and information.

PARK REGULATIONS

Traffic.

The speed limit is 35 miles per hour. Park rangers, in charge of traffic control, investigate all accidents. When necessary they gather material for preparation of court cases to be heard before a park commissioner.

Signal when crossing the road to overlooks. Drive slowly on curves and in rainy weather when roads are slippery. In fog, observe “Travel Not Advised” warnings; they are posted for your safety. If you must proceed, use your driving lights.

The solid centerline in the road is for your safety. Keep to the right. Pass only when your sight distance permits.

Fires.

Build fires only in fireplaces at picnic areas and campgrounds. Be sure your campfire is out! Be careful with cigarettes; do not throw them from your automobile or along the trail. Remember, fire is the forest’s greatest enemy.

Pets.

Dogs and cats must be on a leash at all times, or otherwise confined.

Litter.

You will find trash receptacles in all parking and picnic areas. Deposit your refuse there—do not throw it along the road like a litterbug!

Camping

is limited to 14 days in any one year. Campsites cannot be reserved; when they are filled, rangers will direct you to temporary campgrounds.

Fishing.

A Virginia license is required. Trout fishing only permitted. A 3-day-\$3 nonresident trout fishing license is available at all concession units in the park. Obtain a complete set of fishing regulations from a park ranger at the entrance station as you come into the park, or write to the superintendent for a set.

Firearms.

Assembled firearms and similar devices, including air pistols and rifles, bows and arrows, and slingshots, are prohibited. Shenandoah National Park is a sanctuary for all wildlife, and the hunting, killing, wounding, frightening, or capturing of any wildlife is prohibited.

VISITOR-USE FEES

Vehicle permit fees are collected at entrance stations. If you arrive when an entrance station is unattended, you must obtain a permit before leaving the park. Fees are not listed herein because they are subject to change, but the information may be obtained by writing to the superintendent.

Fee revenues are deposited in the U.S. Treasury; they offset, in part, the cost of operating and maintaining the National Parks.

ADMINISTRATION

Shenandoah National Park is administered by the National Park Service, U.S. Department of the Interior.

The National Park System, of which this park is a unit, is dedicated to conserving the scenic, scientific, and historic heritage of the United States for the benefit and enjoyment of its people.

Development of this park is part of MISSION 66, a 10-year conservation program to unfold the full potential of the National Park System for the use and enjoyment of both present and future generations.

The administrative offices of Shenandoah National Park are located 4 miles west of Thornton Gap and 4 miles east of Luray, Va., on Lee Highway (U.S. 211). If you have questions or comments about the park, send them to the Superintendent, Shenandoah National Park, Luray, Va.

Park Rangers are the protective force of the park, and are assigned to enforce park regulations, and to help and advise you during your stay. Consult them if you are in any difficulty, or need information. Ranger stations are indicated on the map on pages [10](#)-13.

Park Naturalists are here to help you understand and enjoy the park's features. You will meet the naturalists at the visitor center, at evening campfire talks, and on conducted walks. They welcome your questions and comments.

AMERICA'S NATURAL RESOURCES

Created in 1849, the Department of the Interior—America's Department of Natural Resources—is concerned with the management, conservation, and development of the Nation's water, wildlife, mineral, forest, and park and recreational resources. It also has major responsibilities for Indian and territorial affairs.

As the Nation's principal conservation agency, the Department works to assure that nonrenewable resources are developed and used wisely, that park and recreational resources are conserved, and that renewable resources make their full contribution to the progress, prosperity, and security of the United States—now and in the future.



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DEPARTMENT OF THE INTERIOR
NATIONAL PARK SERVICE

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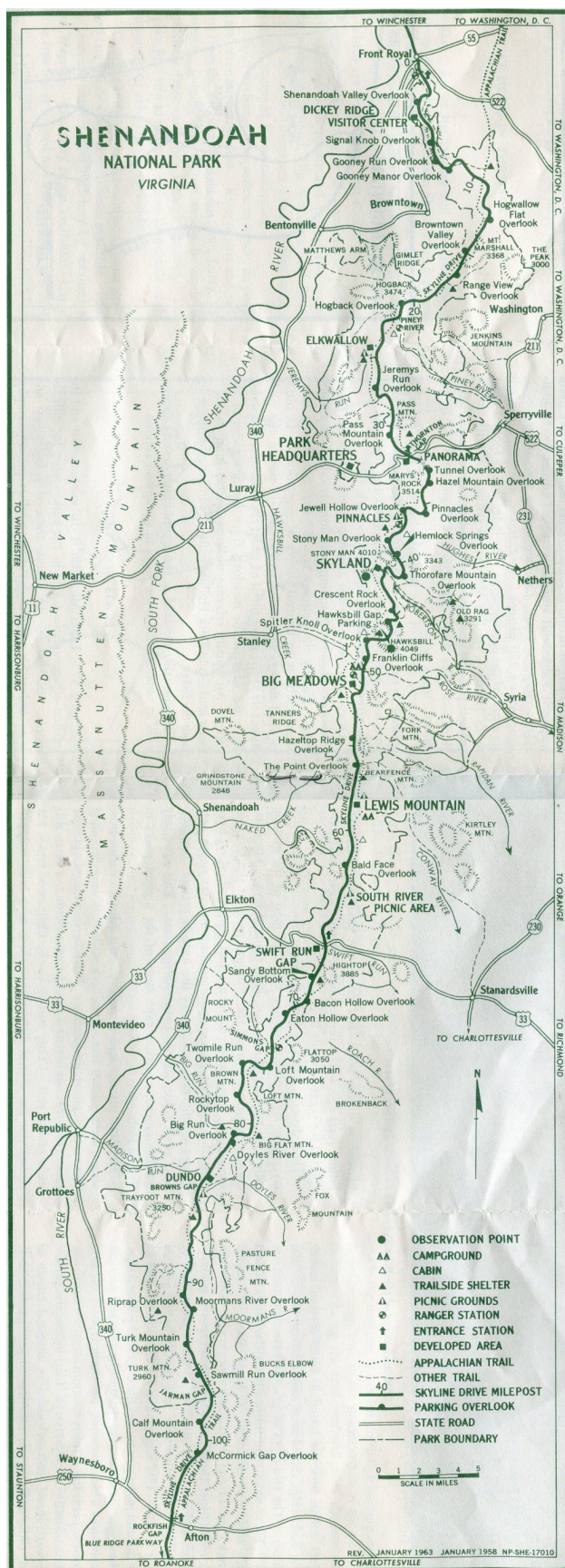
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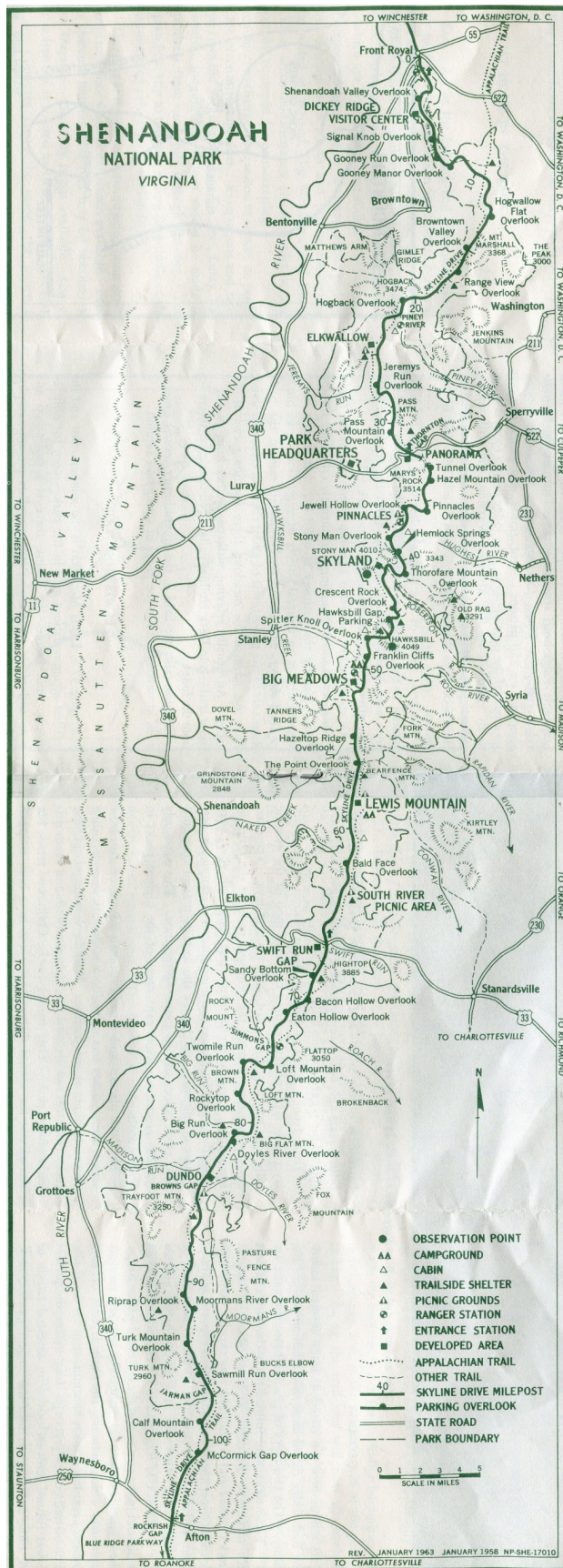
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